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Establishing and Maintaining Customer Support

Steuart Dewar & Jack Miller



Establishing and Maintaining Customer Support

How to provide effective Product Support and Customer Service …and live to spend the profits.



Workshop Agenda

“Between a Rock and a Hard Place”

- Jack Miller, Ecrio inc.

Customer Service in the Palm Economy

- C. E. Steuart Dewar, Pimlico Software, Inc.

Interactive Support Workshop



“A Rock and a Hard Place” – Jack Miller

- But I just want to sell my Software…
- Engineering is only half the work
- Fit the solution to the problem
- Managing in-house resources
- Outsourcing your support



But I just want to sell my Software…

- Your product isn't perfect
- Customers don't tell the complete truth
- Limiting your interaction with customers
- Maximize your impact on your customers
- Use your customer to sell your product
- Finding technical and process solutions



Engineering is only half the work

- Design the product to answer its own questions
- Context sensitive online help
- Get a professional to write the docs
- FAQ’s stink – Make them Helpful
- Use a search engine on the Web for navigating Help notes
- Distribute upgrades the simplest possible way
- Separate data from application to make upgrade painless.



Fit the solution to the problem

- Free-standing Self-supporting software
- Web-based FAQ’s
- Brute-force email support
- Interactive email support
- Artificial Intelligence for email and Web
- Phone support – Yikes!



If it weren't for those $%&*# customers…

- Customers who just don't get it
- Understanding the customer's problem
- You can't make everyone happy
- Dealing with a demanding customer
- Dealing with an obnoxious customer
- Be ready to offer a refund



Managing in-house resources

- Don’t solve the homeless problem
- Hire for technical skills
- Train for “people skills”
- Dedicate at least one “customer owner”
- Scrutinize call logs – Insist on accuracy
- Support your supporters



Selecting an Outsource Service

- Decide what kind of services you need first
- You will pay at least $10K/month!
- Forecast demand carefully
- Prepare a long list of demands
- Benefits of Small shops vs. Large shops
- Watch out for Science Fiction proposals
- Prepare to be nickel-and-dimed to death



Outsourcing Your Customer Support

- Create a bullet-proof Statement of Work
- Train well and often
- Insist on accuracy
- Scrutinize the call logs
- Maintain an active in-house escalation team
- Don’t lose touch with your customers



Folklore and Lessons learned

- Personal interaction makes loyal customers
- Professional informality establishes rapport
- Sometimes solving a problem is better than not having one
- Admit your bugs
- Explain “how it works”



Customer Service in the Palm Economy

C. E. Steuart Dewar, President, Pimlico Software, Inc.



Ask yourself:

What would **you** want that company to do for you...

What would **you** reasonably expect that company to do for you...



Arriving at a Support Strategy

1. What are you trying to accomplish?
2. Classify support tasks
3. Assign/acquire resources
4. Provide relevant tools



What are you trying to accomplish?

- Do absolute minimum you can get away with?
- Minimize your support costs?
- View support as a marketing tool
- **Provide superior support that elevates you above your competitors !**





Classify Support Tasks

- Administrative issues: order fulfillment, etc.
- How to's....Help support
- Reports about Program Bugs
- Chat about the program

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Classify Support Tasks

- Administrative issues: order fulfillment, etc.
  - Outsource



Classify Support Tasks

- Administrative issues: order fulfillment, etc.
  - Outsource · On-line automation



Classify Support Tasks

- Administrative issues: order fulfillment, etc.
  - Outsource · On-line automation · email text search



Classify Support Tasks

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  - Outsource · on-line automation · email text search
- How to's....Help support
  - Readme



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Classify Support Tasks

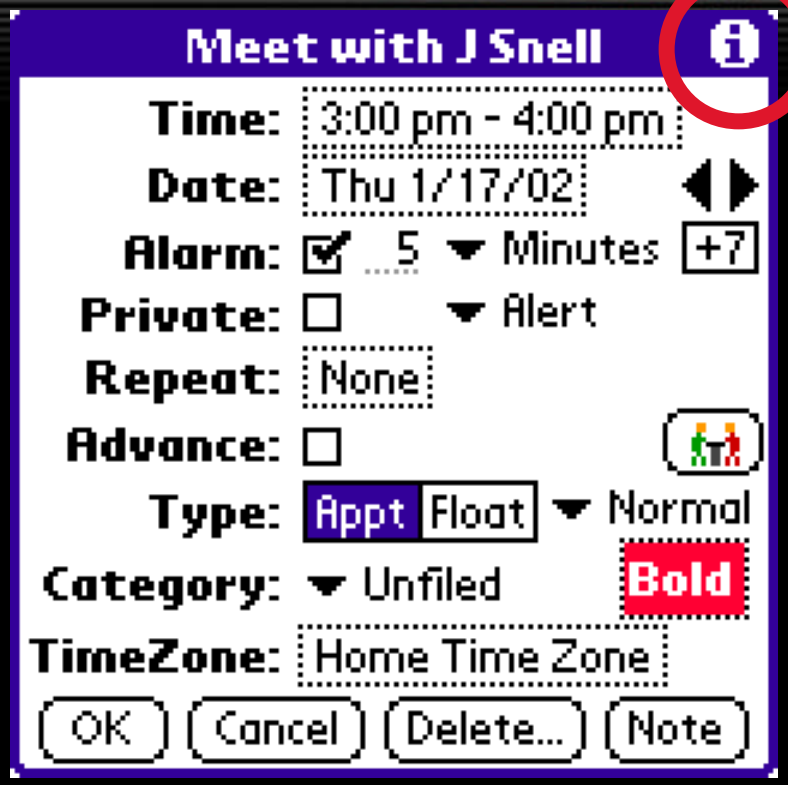
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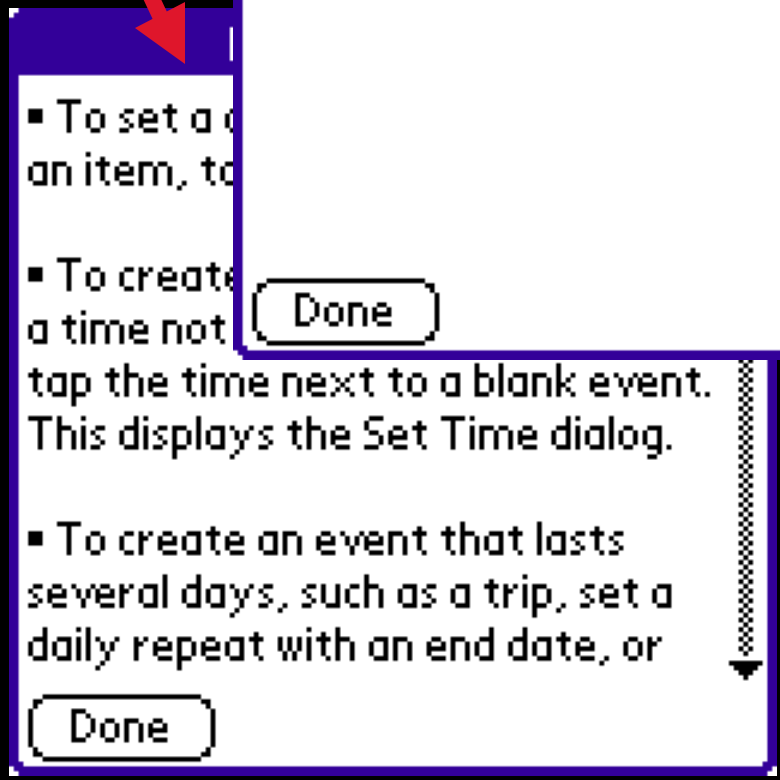
Classify Support Tasks

- Administrative issues: order fulfillment, etc.
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  - Readme · FAQ's · Manuals · Forums · Info Tips...




Meet with J Snell
Time: 3:00 pm - 4:00 pm
Date: Thu 1/17/02
Alarm: 5 Minutes +7
Private: Alert
Repeat: None
Advance:
Type: Appt Float Normal
Category: Unfiled
Bold
TimeZone: Home Time Zone
OK
Cancel
Delete...
Note


DateBk4 Help
Run dbSetup to Install Help System
Done


• To set a
an item, to
• To create
a time not
tap the time next to a blank event.
This displays the Set Time dialog.
• To create an event that lasts
several days, such as a trip, set a
daily repeat with an end date, or
Done



Classify Support Tasks

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- How to's....Help support
  - Readme · FAQ's · Manuals · Forums · Info Tips
- Complaints about Program Bugs
  - Tech Report Forms



BUG DETAILS
Program Name: DateBk4.1
Program Version: P5 (also P3)
Reproducible: Y
Previously reported: N

USER INFORMATION
Name: Peter Meyer
Email: PeterEva@aol.com
Computer Expertise: Intermediate
Datebk3/4 Experience: Expert/Power
Registered User: Y

HARDWARE INFORMATION
Palm Model: M5050
Memory: 8mb
Special Hardware:

SOFTWARE INFORMATION
Palm OS Version: 4
Other 3rd party S/W: TealLock
Hacks Loaded: X-Master, FindHack, MultiClipHack, PalmV Hack, StayOffHack, SwithchHack, TealMemBrain 0.92
Using Saved Views: Y. If YES, do you have a custom startup view? Y
Desktop: PC
Desktop Software: Palm
Conduit Software: Palm



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    Programmer Involvement
- Chat about the program
  - Forums



Classify Support Tasks

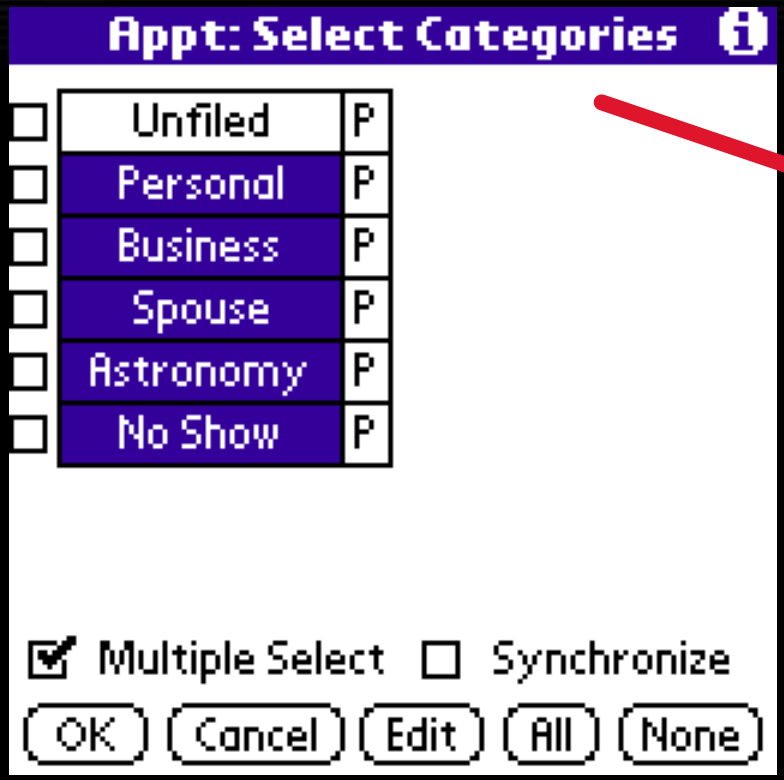
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  - Forums · Programmer Participation

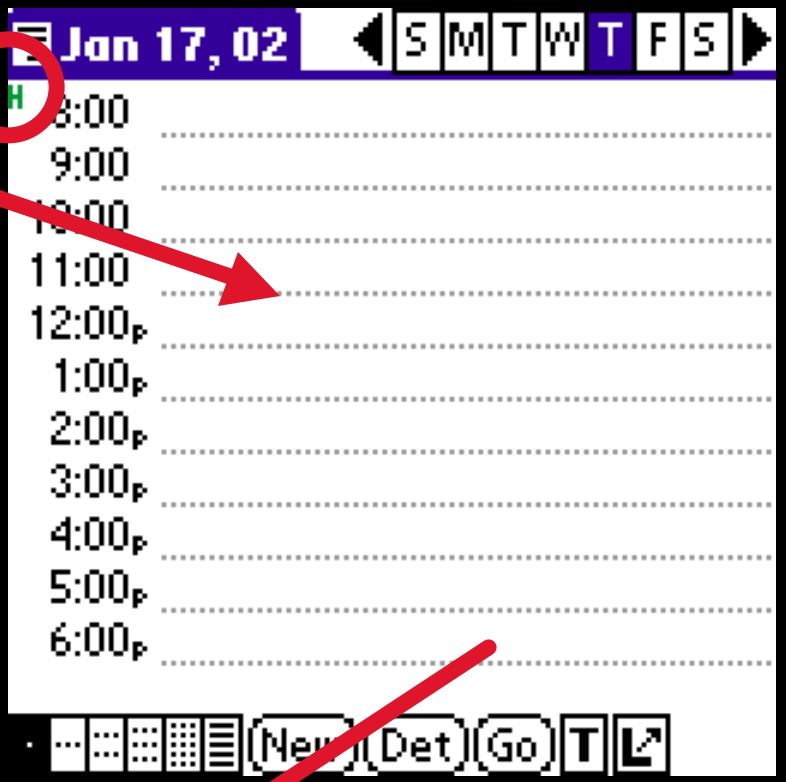


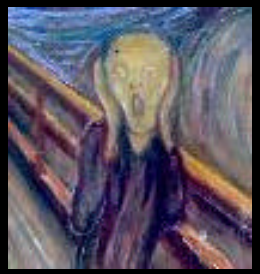
Assign/Acquire Resources

- Outsourcing – only as a last resort
- Hire the **RIGHT** people (givers vs. takers)
- Watch for burnout
- Involve programming staff...

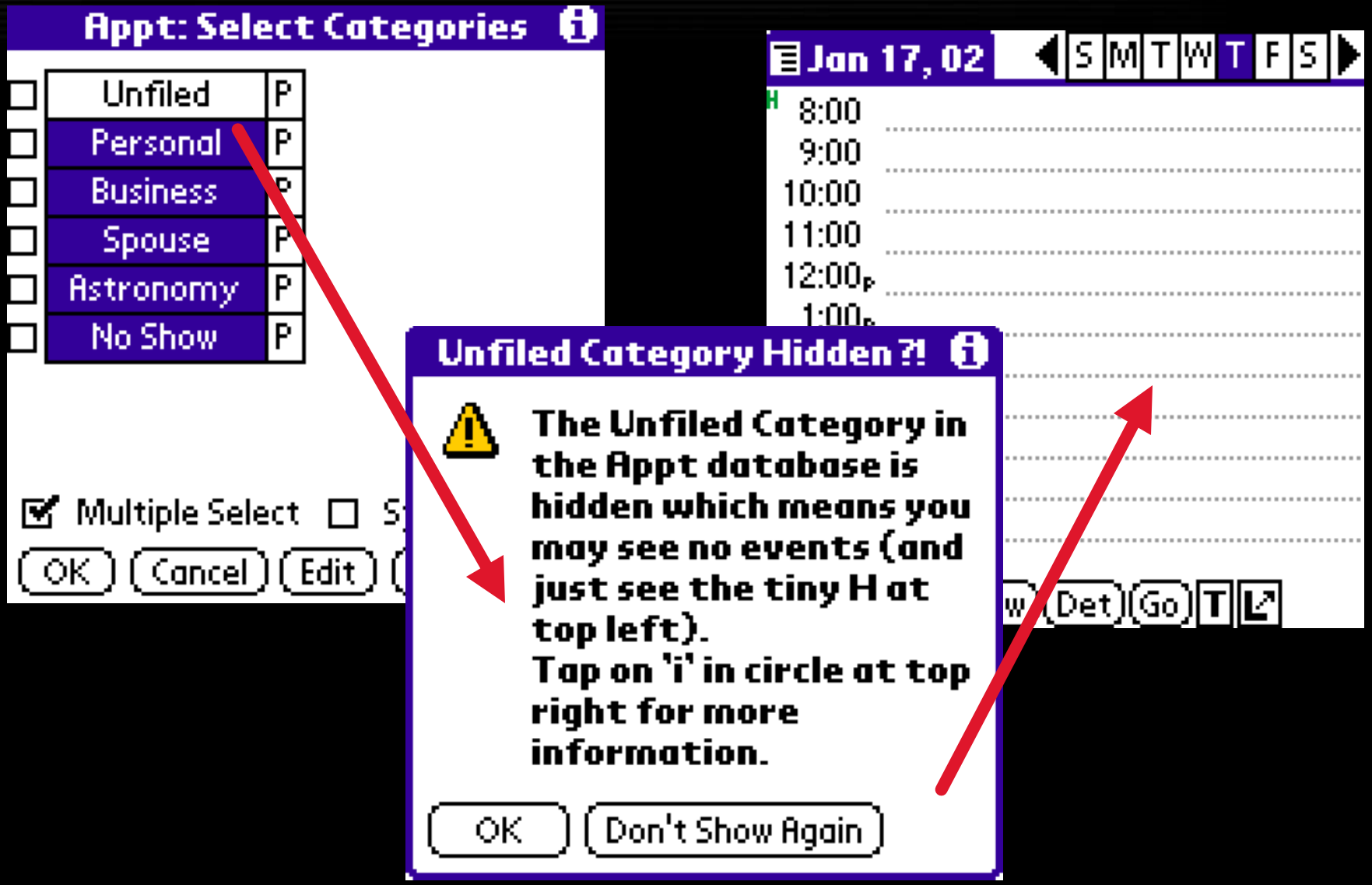
3


Appt: Select Categories
Unfiled P
Personal P
Business P
Spouse P
Astronomy P
No Show P
Multiple Select
Synchronize
OK
Cancel
Edit
All
None


Jan 17, 02
S M T W T F S
9:00
11:00
12:00p
1:00p
2:00p
3:00p
4:00p
5:00p
6:00p
New
Det
Go






Appt: Select Categories
Unfiled
Personal
Business
Spouse
Astronomy
No Show
Multiple Select
OK
Cancel
Edit
Jan 17, 02
S M T W T F S
8:00
9:00
10:00
11:00
12:00
Det
Go
Unfiled Category Hidden ?!
The Unfiled Category in the Appt database is hidden which means you may see no events (and just see the tiny H at top left).
Tap on 'i' in circle at top right for more information.
OK
Don't Show Again



Provide Relevant Tools

- Reliable, industrial strength database
- Email configured with routing rules
- Macro key/boilerplate text insertion tools
- Archive collective emails into knowledge base
- Telephone Support? 800 numbers? maybe not
- Force support people to use Palm™ devices
- Force support people to use your software
- Put a “face” on your support staff

4



If you have done the job right...

" Many thanks, it worked immediately ! Your service is outstanding: fast, friendly and efficient. You should give some lessons to the people from Microsoft."

"As always, thanks for the excellent support - it would be nice if Microsoft had 1/100th this kind of customer service..."



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